

demagogue

A politician whose power base relies on stirring up the emotions of the people of a country through charismatic and emotional speeches, often in opposition to established authority.

democracy

A political system in which the people of a country control their government. **Direct democracy**, which operated in ancient Athens, allowed citizens to decide policy by direct votes. Most democracy is **representative democracy**, with the people electing politicians to represent them. Democracy has often been popular with groups that are excluded from voting, such as women and non-property owners.

denomination

A body of religious believers sharing a common faith and organization and having a recognized name; most commonly applied to sections within the Christian Church—for example, Baptists and Methodists.

dependency

A subordinate territory that does not form an integral part of the country which has overall control of it.

despotism

An *autocracy*, especially one that is headed by a king or emperor. An **enlightened despot** is one who is seen as ruling for the benefit of the people rather than for him/herself. Also refers to the exercise of power itself by the ruler.

detente

The lessening of tension between two countries; used especially for the time when tension was decreasing between the US and the former USSR.

devaluation

The lowering in value of one country's currency compared with other currencies.

diaspora

The members of a particular ethnic group (see *ethnicity*) who are living away from their land of origin. It was originally used with reference to the Jews.

dictator

Originally an official in ancient Rome who was given sweeping powers for a short period during a time of national emergency. Now used for any person who rules a country alone and with no effective restrictions on their individual power. The word is not normally applied to hereditary kings or emperors, unlike the similar terms autocrat and despot (see *autocracy* and *despotism*).

dissolution

In general, this means the process of dissolving or separating into constituent parts. The **Dissolution of Parliament** is the official end of a parliament before a general election is held to elect new representatives. The **Dissolution of the Monasteries** was the disbanding of monasteries and other religious institutions in 16th-century England during the reign of Henry VIII.

dominion/Dominions

(1) The right to govern or control. (2) Any territory owing allegiance to a particular ruler or government. (3) A term formerly used, especially the plural (Dominions), for the larger self-governing territories within the British Empire, especially Canada and Australia.

dynasty

A royal family that rules over a country for several generations.

Eastern Bloc

The communist (see *communism*) countries of eastern Europe during the *Cold War* period.

ecclesiastical

Relating to the Church or to the clergy.

ecumenical

Relating to: (1) the whole of the Christian Church; (2) movements aimed at reuniting different branches of the Church.

ethnicity

Characteristics and features associated with belonging to a particular ethnic group, which may be defined purely by culture or with reference to biological or racial characteristics.

evangelical

Relating to: (1) the Christian Gospels; (2) Protestant (see *Protestantism*) doctrines that emphasize personal salvation by faith; (3) religious movements that actively go out to preach to and convert others (to **evangelize**).

excommunication

The action taken by a religious organization of cutting off an individual from communication or membership of the organization, and/or from taking part in its rites.

fascism

Originally, the ideology of the political movement led by Benito Mussolini, who was in power in Italy between 1922 and 1943. Fascist doctrines were *authoritarian*, antidemocratic (see *democracy*), and anticommunist (see *communism*); they emphasized subjection of the individual to the state and tended to glorify war and *nationalism*. The term **fascist** is now used loosely for any ideology or attitude seen as authoritarian or intolerant.

fatwa

In *Islam*, a pronouncement, especially by a cleric, that gives an opinion and/or seeks to direct an action.

federal system

Any political system where there is an overall central government (**federal government**), but with many areas of decision-making being carried out by regional governments—for example, governments of provinces or states; the division of powers between the federal and regional governments is normally guaranteed by a constitution.

feudalism

The elaborate social system that grew up in *Medieval* Europe, where each nation was conceived of as a “pyramid,” with a monarch at the top. Each level of society was entitled to claim rights from, but also obliged to undertake duties to, those “above” and “below” in the hierarchy.

fiefs

Lands held on condition of service offered to a superior lord under the feudal system (see *feudalism*).

free trade

Trading of goods and services between countries without restrictions, such as quota limits or taxes on imported goods. See also *protectionism*.

fundamentalism

A strict belief in all the traditional teachings of a given religion.

genocide

The systematic extermination of a racial or ethnic group (see *ethnicity*).

globalization

The process by which improved communications and international links have resulted in ideas, cultures, labor markets, and ways of life becoming increasingly widespread and/or interconnected globally.

gnosticism

Any of various religious ideologies and movements that emphasize the acquiring of secret or mystical knowledge as a way to salvation. Gnosticism was widespread in early Christianity, but came to be regarded as heretical (see *heresy*) by the Church.

Gothic

(1) Relating to the Goths, a Germanic tribe that invaded the Roman Empire in the 3rd and 4th centuries CE; (2) A style of European architecture that flourished from the 13th to 16th centuries, and was characterized by distinctive pointed windows and other features. Most of the great *Medieval* cathedrals were built in this style.

Greek Church

The branch of the Christian Church associated with the (Greek-speaking) *Byzantine Empire*, in which church services were conducted in Greek. See also *Orthodox Church*.

guerrilla warfare

Warfare where the fighters operate in small irregular units, often without uniforms or an official army structure.

guild

A *Medieval* mutual-aid association. Craftsmen and merchants in towns were often organized into guilds, and individuals were often only allowed to practise their trade if they belonged to the guild of that particular trade.

hegemony

A situation in which a powerful country exerts a significant influence over its less powerful neighbors.

heresy

Usually a minority belief or tendency within a given religion that is regarded as unacceptable or even evil by other adherents to the religion. A **heretic** is a person regarded as heretical.

Holy Roman Empire

An empire set up in Western Europe in *Medieval* times, whose territory was centred on modern-day Germany. Both connected to and forming a rival to the papacy, it increasingly took the form of a loose collection of states. The emperor of the Holy Roman Empire held little power by the time it was formally abolished by Napoleon in 1806.

hominin

A member of the biological group that includes humans and their extinct ancestors and relatives, back to the point at which they split from the line leading to chimpanzees.

Huguenots

Historical term for French Protestants (see *Protestantism*), whose history of persecution led many to emigrate and settle in other countries.

humanist

(1) A Latin or Greek scholar, especially of the *Renaissance* period. The work of Renaissance humanists involved the rediscovery of classical texts and their human-centered values, as opposed to the emphasis on God and theology of the *Medieval period*. (2) A person who advocates an ethical approach to human life that does not involve belief in a god or gods.

imperialism

Originally the system of government or rule in an empire. Now, more particularly, the attitudes of mind that supported the acquisition of distant territories by 19th-century Western powers.

Iron Curtain

Term for the barrier between the USSR-dominated communist countries (see *communism*) of Eastern Europe and the capitalist West during the *Cold War*.

Islam

A monotheistic (single-god) religion established in the 7th century CE in Arabia by the Prophet Muhammad. Islam means “submission” (to God). The two main branches of Islam, **Sunni** and **Shi'ite**, differ in the authority and legitimacy they ascribe to different members of the Prophet's family after his death.

Islamism

A tendency within *Islam* that aims to establish Islamic law and values in societies worldwide.

isolationism

A policy of isolating a country from international disputes, especially by not taking part in alliances. The term is particularly associated with certain periods of Chinese, Japanese, and US history.